

Josh Nykamp

Senior Director of Engineering

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Senior Director of Engineering with 15 years of experience building and scaling engineering organizations in high-compliance, high-scale consumer products. Proven track record leading org-wide transformation — including an AI-native SDLC rollout using Claude and cloud agents that cut cycle time 30% — and scaling teams from 11 to 50+ engineers with zero regrettable attrition. Deep experience in M&A integration, having led post-acquisition engineering integration following a \$750M acquisition.

CORE COMPETENCIES

- ▶ Engineering Leadership & Org Design
- ▶ AI-Native SDLC Transformation
- ▶ M&A Engineering Integration
- ▶ DevOps & CI/CD Transformation
- ▶ Cross-Functional Team Leadership
- ▶ Talent Development & Career Laddering
- ▶ Distributed & Offshore Team Management
- ▶ Architecture & Systems Design
- ▶ Product & Platform Scaling
- ▶ Stakeholder & Executive Communication
- ▶ Change Management
- ▶ Hiring & Retention at Scale

EXPERIENCE

Senior Director of Engineering — DraftKings 2024 — Present · Remote

- Led transformation of the SDLC to an AI-native SDLC across 5 engineering teams — every DraftKings-acquired-company team on GitHub (vs. Bitbucket) — deploying Claude, Gemini, Qwen, and GitHub Copilot for planning, Jira story authoring, and debugging, cutting cycle time by 30%
- Led post-acquisition integration of Jackpocket's engineering org into DraftKings following the \$750M acquisition — right-sized the team from 70 to 50 engineers as functions were absorbed into shared DraftKings departments
- Expanded lottery product line — launched keno and scaled scratchers across 5 states, generating \$3M in incremental ARR
- Converted ticket discovery and segmentation from OCR/Tesseract to Qwen-based AI OCR, cutting the system's response to ticket-format changes from days of engineering work to little-to-no change required
- Founded a new hardware engineering team (EM, principal architect, electrical engineer, mechanical engineer, plus contractor electrical/mechanical engineers) building automated lottery and scratcher dispensing machines

VP of Engineering — Jackpocket (acquired by DraftKings) 2021 — 2024 · Remote

- Inherited a single large team with no clear ownership boundaries; split engineering into dedicated ecommerce and fulfillment orgs with separate backlogs and independent release cycles
- Redesigned core architecture around a message bus with a testable interface, decoupling ecommerce and fulfillment so each could ship independently
- Ran an Accelerate book club and drove full DevOps adoption — within 6 months the team went from 1-2 releases per month to deploying many times per day behind feature flags, eliminating rollbacks
- Launched scratchers in 2022, adding a new line of business to the platform later scaled to 5 states generating \$3M in ARR
- Grew the engineering org from 11 to 50 engineers, 3 SREs, 2 security engineers, and 5 managers over 3 years with no regrettable attrition
- Built a test suite and CI/CD pipeline robust enough to eliminate QA entirely by 2024
- Grew Jackpocket into a \$750M acquisition by DraftKings in 2024

Director of Engineering — Weedmaps Sep 2019 — Jun 2021 · Irvine, CA (Remote)

- Partnered with GM to write the business plan, gather requirements, and define product specs for Weedmaps Exchange — the company's B2B wholesale marketplace
- Hired 13 engineers to build Weedmaps Exchange; launched May 2019 — within 6 months it was generating \$3M in monthly GMV
- Hired and developed Engineering Managers; managed offshore teams in Costa Rica and Colombia
- Authored the Weedmaps Engineering Career Ladder and review process; designed new SDLC to improve team performance tracking

Engineering Manager — Weedmaps Aug 2017 — Sep 2019 · Irvine, CA

- Built and launched Weedmaps Logistics — Android/iOS driver apps and a web dispatch interface for managing pickup orders and assigning drivers
- Managed 2 cross-functional teams of 8 engineers with zero attrition; maintained 98% test coverage and 99.9% uptime across all production systems
- Piloted Elixir adoption to replace Ruby; created an Elixir training program to upskill existing engineers and onboard new hires
- Created a junior engineer training program; hired 50+ engineers across the organization

Senior Software Engineer — Weedmaps Oct 2016 — Aug 2017 · Irvine, CA

- Built a GraphQL API using Elixir/Phoenix; developed frontend applications in React, GraphQL, and Apollo
- Established Docker-based development environments across engineering teams

Senior Software Engineer — Contractor — NBC (via Gorilla Logic) 2016 · Remote

- Converted NBC.com from Drupal 7 to a headless architecture with a Node.js/React frontend
- Built live streaming infrastructure for Olympic coverage on Drupal 7

Software Engineer — TalentReef 2014 — 2015

- Built a SaaS platform for social recruiting of hourly employees using Drupal; developed custom modules and managed CentOS servers
- Managed migration from outsourced to in-house development; decoupled the Drupal view layer using Angular

Software Engineer — I-Behavior

2013

- Built internal web applications at a big data company using Laravel and Angular

Software Engineer — New Frontier Media / Hustler

2011 — 2013

- Built a single sign-on 360° web experience for cable subscribers
- Co-developed one of the first adult smart TV applications — built a custom JavaScript UI framework backed by a PHP API at the dawn of the smart TV era

SKILLS

Leadership: Engineering Management, Org Design, Hiring & Talent Development, Career Laddering, Offshore Team Management, OKRs & SDLC, AI-Native SDLC Transformation

Languages & Frameworks: Elixir / Phoenix, Ruby on Rails, Python, Node.js, React, GraphQL / Apollo, PHP / Laravel / Drupal, TypeScript

Infrastructure: GCP, RabbitMQ, Docker, Android / iOS, Distributed Systems, High-Scale Architecture, Headless CMS, API Design, Smart TV / Embedded

AI Tooling: Claude, Gemini, Qwen, GitHub Copilot, AI-Driven OCR, AI Agent Tooling

EDUCATION & MILITARY

Miami Ad School

Advertising & Photography
2005 — 2006

Santa Barbara City College

General Studies
2004 — 2005

U.S. Navy

Avionics Technician & Rescue Swimmer
2000 — 2004